



Trusted the Tag, Checked It Anyway

Parents’ trust in a swing set’s safety tag, and whether they check it anyway

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Background

Municipal playgrounds post a laminated inspection tag zip-tied to the swing-set frame. Little is known about whether a parent’s trust in that tag tracks its own currency, or whether they check the equipment themselves regardless of what the tag says.

Aims

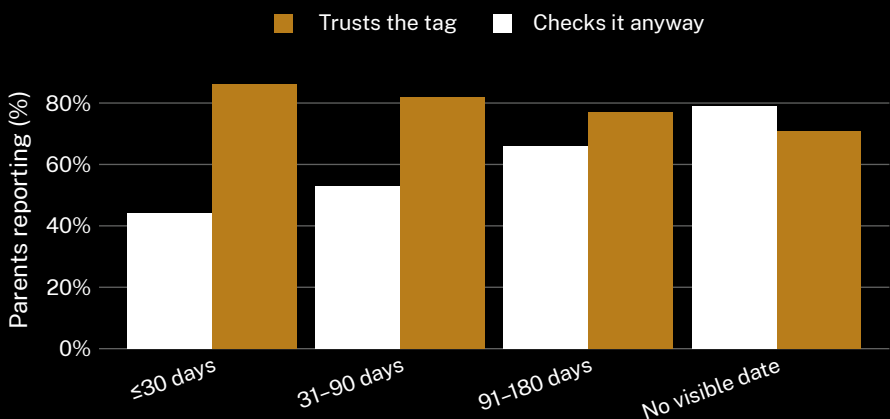
- Measure parental trust in a playground’s zip-tied safety-inspection tag
- Compare stated trust against self-reported pre-climb equipment checks
- Test whether both track the tag’s own inspection date

Methods

- n = 342 parents · intercept survey · 14 suburban playground sites · 6 weeks
- 5-point trust scale; yes/no self-reported pre-climb check; tag-date band read on-site by the surveying researcher, not asked of the parent
- Cross-tab pre-registered against weeks since the tag’s last inspection stamp
- Excluded: parents who could not see the tag from their usual bench or supervision position

Results

Reported trust in the tag slides only 15 points between a stamp dated within the month and no visible date at all. Self-reported pre-climb checking moves more than twice as far over the same span, and the two measures cross before the tag reaches its fourth undated month.



Self-reported trust holds at 71-86% across every tag-date band; self-reported personal checking climbs from 44% to 79% over the same bands (n = 342, six-week intercept survey, 2026).

Discussion & conclusions

A parent’s trust in the tag appears to function as a floor, not a substitute: hand-checking rises fastest exactly where trust has the furthest left to fall. Tag and parent look like complementary instruments, not competing ones, and neither one alone accounts for the caution actually applied at the swing set. The gap also narrows a known asymmetry in self-report safety research: stated vigilance typically overstates observed vigilance, yet here the overstatement itself tracks a checkable field variable rather than floating free of it. Whether that tracking reflects a genuinely calibrated parent or a socially desirable answer shaped by a visible, dateable prompt is not something a survey alone can settle. Next: unobtrusive video coding of at-play checking behaviour, to test whether the self-report gap survives observation, and whether a re-dated tag measurably resets it.

References

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We thank the caretakers of the fourteen surveyed play spaces for scheduling access around opening hours.

Approved under minimal-risk protocol; only accompanying adults surveyed, no child interviewed or photographed.

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